



DESIGN NOTE

LDF Alignment

ANALYTICAL AND VISUAL FRAMEWORK: FIRST OUTPUT

New Zealand Army Leadership Centre | Army Command School

Reference: NZDF Leadership Framework v2 (Oct 2025); LDS, Leadership Levels and Leadership Framework posters · **Date:** September 2026 · **Status:** **Design draft for approval**

1. Purpose of this Note

This note is the first output for the AITC discussion piece on Army leadership development and promotion alignment. It does not answer the question. It sets out the analytical and visual structure through which the question can be answered, the seven-page wireframe sequence, the data still required, and the assumptions that have deliberately not been made.

The tasking from COMDT ACS is to consider how the Officer and Other Rank promotion continuums align with the intent and design of the LDF, present the facts, and challenge the organisation to decide about the development of leaders at all levels. The piece therefore carries three wordings, each with a fixed place.

Place	Wording
Headline (page 1)	How well do the Army's Officer and Other Rank promotion continuums align with the intent and design of the LDF?
Analytical test (pages 4 to 6)	At each LDF transition: does the continuum deliberately develop the individual for the change in leadership required, and is that development linked to promotion?
Closing (page 7)	Given these facts, how should Army decide about the development of leaders at all levels?

"LDF" is used throughout as COMDT's term for the NZDF Leadership Framework and Leadership Development System taken together, and is defined once on page 2.

2. The Source Architecture

What the sources are

Source	What it establishes
NZDF Leadership Framework poster	Six Key Elements and 27 Essential Tasks that apply at every level. The elements are constant; their expression changes.
NZDF Leadership Development System poster	Seven levels, each entered by "commencement of the first role" at that level; an LDS course for each level; the Orientation, Build and Advance phases of transition; development occurring 10 percent on course, 20 percent through coaching and mentoring, 70 percent through guided experimentation on the job.
NZDF Leadership Levels poster	An approximate mapping of NZDF ranks and pay codes to the seven levels across six transitions. The poster itself states the alignment is "only an estimation" and that a true alignment would come from analysing individual position descriptions.
NZDF Leadership Framework document (v2, October 2025)	The Value Adds for each level, which state the leadership purpose and mindset required; the one-page Leader Development Guides (Essential Tasks and Behaviour Statements); the three leadership environments; and the intent that Essential Tasks map to the PDR.

Three things the sources make clear

1. **The framework is the "what". The system is the "how far".** The six Key Elements never change. The seven levels describe progressively different leadership environments, each defined by the scope and scale of the leadership tasks and responsibilities.
2. **The transition is where the work is.** The LDS poster places the LDS course before the first posting to a new level and describes a three-phase transition (Orientation, Build, Advance). The Value Adds are written explicitly to be different from the level below and the level above, so that leaders "understand, and prepare for, how they add unique value at the next leadership level".
3. **The rank mapping is not doctrine.** The Leadership Levels poster is an estimate. Any Army rank-to-level alignment used in the analysis must therefore be treated as a hypothesis to confirm, not a given.

The three environments

The LDF groups the seven levels into three environments, each with its own cultural responsibility. This grouping is useful because the largest mindset changes sit at the environment boundaries.

Environment	Levels	Cultural responsibility
Foundational (Paparahi)	Lead Self, Lead Teams, Lead Leaders	Tone: set and monitor the tone of the team
Operational (Paheko)	Lead Systems, Lead Capability	Climate: develop and monitor unit climate
Strategic (Rautaki)	Lead Integrated Capability, Lead Organisation	Culture: monitor and develop organisational culture

3. What Changes at Each Transition

The table distils the distinctive developmental shift at each level from the Value Adds and level introductions in the LDF document. The distilled statement is the one line that will appear on page 3 of the discussion piece. The source headings are listed so every statement is traceable.

Level	Distilled shift	Value Adds in the source
Lead Self	Effective individual contribution: deliver on the leader's intent, master the role, support the team.	Follow leader's intent; Apply good judgement; Support others; Pursue excellence
Lead Teams	Accountable for others for the first time. Get things done through others and set the tone.	Coach and develop a team; Align with unit objectives; Set the tone; Get things done through others
Lead Leaders	Get things done through other leaders. Step back from direct control, think in systems, connect teams to the organisation.	Coach team leaders; Get things done through other leaders; Adopt systems thinking; Connect teams to the organisation
Lead Systems	Run an entire system with delegated autonomy. Turn capability intent into priorities and plans; grow the next operational leaders.	Grow curious leaders; Explain the why and the what; Run an entire system
Lead Capability	Build and sustain capability beyond your own tenure. Turn strategy into action and advise upward honestly.	Turn strategy into action; Provide sound and honest advice upwards; Build capability by expanding professional expertise; Create a positive unit climate
Lead Integrated Capability	Lead at enterprise level: integrate capabilities, work with external partners, develop strategic leaders. The source calls this "a significant shift in skill and mind-set".	Develop strategic leaders; Promote strategic collaboration; Implement the strategic agenda; Promote organisational excellence
Lead Organisation	Institutional stewardship: create the strategic agenda, maintain ministerial confidence, own the culture and the Leadership Development System.	Evolve organisational systems; Facilitate strategic collaboration; Create the strategic agenda; Maintain ministerial confidence; Lead organisational culture

The six transitions between these levels, T1 to T6, are the unit of analysis for everything that follows.

4. The Analytical Model

One spine, two continuums

The central visual holds the NZDF LDF fixed in the middle as the doctrinal reference, with the Army Officer continuum on the left and the Army Other Rank continuum on the right. The two continuums are never merged. The purpose is to see, for each transition, where Officer development aligns, where OR development aligns, where both do, where one does better than the other, where development exists but is disconnected from promotion, where it happens too early or too late, where nothing exists, and where the policy or data is unclear.

Rows are transitions, not levels

Each row of the matrix is a transition: the current level, the developmental shift, and the new level. The row applies the analytical test to each continuum: does it deliberately develop the individual for this shift, and is that development linked to promotion?

Six categories per side

Each continuum answers the same six questions for every transition. The Officer columns run right-to-left and the OR columns left-to-right, so the same category sits the same distance from the spine on both sides.

1. **Rank / career point.** Which promotion or career transition corresponds to this LDF transition?
2. **Appointment / responsibility.** What increased leadership responsibility is assumed?
3. **Formal development.** What course, programme or intervention exists?
4. **Career linkage.** Prerequisite for promotion; embedded in a promotion course; prerequisite for appointment; expected but not mandatory; or disconnected.
5. **Timing.** Before, at, or after the transition; or unclear.
6. **Assurance.** How Army knows the individual is ready to operate at the new level.

Status language

The headline asks "how well", so the answer for each transition is a degree, read across the row as the balance of aligned cells, named gaps and unknowns, rather than a yes or no. Every cell carries one of three states until the data is complete. The state is written in the cell as a short tag, so the matrix reads correctly in greyscale and colour is an addition rather than the carrier of meaning.

Tag	Meaning	Colour in the polished version
KNOWN	Confirmed against an authoritative source	Green where aligned; otherwise a named gap
TO CONFIRM	Something in hand, but from an estimate or a working document rather than policy	Amber
DATA REQUIRED	Nothing in hand	Grey

Gap taxonomy

Where a gap is identified it is named by type rather than only coloured red, so the reader sees the nature of the problem.

Gap type	Definition
DEVELOPMENT	No deliberate development identified for the transition.
ALIGNMENT	Development exists but does not correspond cleanly with the LDF transition.
TIMING	Development occurs after the individual has already transitioned.
CONSEQUENCE	Appropriate development exists but has no formal relationship with promotion or appointment.
ASSURANCE	No clear mechanism establishes readiness for the next leadership level.
DATA	Insufficient information currently available.

5. The Seven Pages and Their Visual Logic

The wireframes are in the accompanying PDF. Each page carries its own annotation. In summary:

1. **The question.** Type only. COMDT's question in his own terms, generous space, nothing competing. The reader should be able to repeat it afterwards.
2. **The system we already have.** Three posters become one picture: the ring of six constant elements, the staircase of seven levels with the three environments as faint bands, and a single axis of increasing scope, scale, complexity and consequence. One message line: the framework remains constant; its expression changes as responsibility increases.
3. **What actually changes.** Seven columns, one bold sentence each, with the source Value Add headings beneath for traceability. The six transition gates, T1 to T6, are introduced here and reused on every later page.

4. **Two career systems, one leadership framework.** The centrepiece matrix, with the analytical test stated once above it. Dark spine, mirrored columns, status tags. Populated only with what the four sources support: the LDS delivery model per level and the rank estimate from the Leadership Levels poster, both tagged TO CONFIRM. Everything else is DATA REQUIRED.
5. **Where do the systems align.** The identical grid with everything that is not demonstrably aligned faded out. Green is used here and nowhere earlier.
6. **Where are the gaps.** The identical grid with each gap named by type. Officer-versus-OR asymmetry is read across a row. Amber and red appear only on this page and page 5.
7. **The question for Army.** Type only again, in COMDT's words: given these facts, how should Army decide about the development of leaders at all levels? The three levers AITC controls are named (promotion, appointment, professional development) with no option or recommendation attached.

Three rules hold across the set: the grid never changes shape between pages 4, 5 and 6; colour is never the only carrier of meaning; and nothing appears in a cell that a source does not support.

6. What Is Missing

The four sources describe the NZDF system. They contain almost nothing about the Army career continuum, which is the other half of the comparison. Specifically, the analysis cannot proceed to findings without:

1. Army promotion policy for each rank, Officer and OR, and the prerequisites it sets.
2. The Army career-development continuum documents for both continuums.
3. The full list of Army promotion and career courses in SOLO, with the LDS content each includes or requires.
4. ILD delivery data for Lead Systems and above: which Army ranks attend, when, and whether attendance is mandated.
5. The mapping of LDF Essential Tasks to the Army PDR, and whether PDR outcomes reach promotion boards.
6. Any readiness assessment applied at first appointment to a new level.
7. The authoritative Army view of which rank equates to each LDF level, replacing the poster estimate.

The accompanying spreadsheet lists every cell of the matrix as a row to populate: 72 transition-by-continuum-by-category items plus the eight cross-cutting items above. Rows already carrying something from the sources are marked TO CONFIRM with the evidence quoted.

7. Assumptions Deliberately Not Made

1. That the Leadership Levels poster's rank mapping is authoritative for Army. It is labelled an estimate and is used only as a hypothesis.
2. That an LDS course exists in Army delivery at every level. The LDS poster describes NZDF intent; Army delivery is not evidenced.
3. That ELDA courses are the LDS courses. The NZALC course data sheets developed in this project reference LDS courses as prerequisites or sequencing, which implies they are distinct. This is recorded as TO CONFIRM.
4. That promotion courses contain or require leadership development aligned to the transition. Nothing in the four sources says so.
5. That development occurring within a promotion course occurs before the transition. Whether a promotion course sits before or after assumption of the new role is a Timing question for the data.

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6. That the PDR functions as assurance. The LDF says Essential Tasks map to the PDR; whether Army uses that mapping to establish readiness is unknown.
7. That Officer and OR transitions happen at the same career age or in the same order of appointment. The two continuums are kept separate precisely so this is not assumed.
8. That Warrant Officer tiers correspond to the operational and strategic levels in the way the poster suggests.
9. That Nemesis, the Leadership Journal, or any other NZALC activity discussed in this project is part of the formal continuum. They are not entered anywhere in the matrix.
10. That Reserve Force, lateral entrants and civilian leaders are in scope. This is raised as a scoping decision for AITC.

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